

Burners — Examples of Play

Mechanics-only run-throughs of the engine (Fuel pools, Defend, soak-on-the-way-in, negative-HP wounds). No narration — just procedure, rolls, and the gauge. See [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Example 1 — The Rat-Cellars (a crawl)

Job: clear the Rat-Cellars under Varn's granary; recover the strongbox. **Base Heat 6** (working ground). Torches burn 6 turns. Wandering check every 2nd turn, 1-in-6 (OSE procedure, unchanged).

Crew (all character level 1 — one Approach point, four Traits, HP = 1d6 rolled):

Burner	Approach	HP	Held	Fuel on the Initiative roll
Kragg	Sword 1 (Veteran)	4	war-axe (3 slots, 2-handed, enchanted), gambeson (AC 2)	4 empty + 3 axe + 1 level = 8
Sefa	Craft 1 (Journeyman)	3	leather (AC 1); silvered knife (1 slot) once looted	4 empty + 1 knife + 1 level = 6
Brand	Heart 1 (Boss)	5	sword (2), leather (AC 1)	4 empty + 2 sword + 1 level = 7
Ilsa	Sorcerie 1 (Sorcerer)	3	spear (3 physical); 5 Arcana (hand size 5 — <i>dart</i> ready among them); wand drip in Arcana; leather (AC 1)	5 Arcana + 3 spear + 1 level = 9 (no empty physical)

Reminder — out of combat: 2d6 + Approach vs Cost. Hostile magic: Fuel Defend vs cast total (see [[Burners Principles#Granular defense, not binary save]]).

Exploration

Turn 1 — Entry stair.

- Sefa scouts (Craft): Pay @ Heat 6 → 2d6+1 = **8** ✓. Clear, no cost.
- Torch 1/6.

Turn 2 — Cellar 1, flooded. A slick beam (balance — Defend, Craft).

- Cross, 2d6 + Craft vs Heat 6 each:
 - Kragg 2d6 = **7** ✓ · Sefa 2d6+1 = **9** ✓ · Ilsa 2d6 = **10** ✓ · Brand 2d6 = **5**, short → slips, splash and noise → **Heat 7**.
- Wandering check: d6 = **4**. Nothing.

Turn 3 — Stuck door (heavy, swollen — a hard feat, Sword vs 9).

- Kragg heaves: $2d6+1 = 8$, short → holds, time burns.
- Second try: $2d6+1 = 10$ ✓ — it grinds open.
- Torch 3/6.

Turn 4 — Cellar 2. Covered pit (trap: flat Damage 2, no roll — detect or eat).

- Sefa checks for traps (Craft): Pay @ 7 → $2d6+1 = 6$, short 1 → **Heat 8**. Pit *not* spotted.
- Marching order puts Brand on it. It springs, no telegraph, no Fuel up out of combat: Damage 2 – Brand's AC 1 (soaks on the way in) = **1 to HP**. Brand 5 → 4.
- Wandering check: $d6 = 1$ — encounter. Cellar denizens, hostile by writ: **4 grave-rats** (HD 1, 5 HP each, bite $d6 \rightarrow 2$ slots).

Combat 1 — Grave-rats (4). Heat 8

Rolling Initiative. Crew roll their Fuel (above). The rat pack rolls one pool — 4 (a die per HD) + 2 (best bite) + 8 (Heat) = **14 dice** — and, ganging like a Veteran of many levels, makes one attack per rat (each its own 1-die blow, each defended separately). Initiative is the count of 3s and 4s; Kragg reads highest and acts first.

Round 1.

- **Kragg** attacks: spends a 5 → 5 dmg, rat 1 (5 HP) dead. He rolled a 6 — plays it as a **Spark** for a second attack, spends the 6 → rat 2 dead.
- **Brand** attacks: spends a 5 → rat 3 dead.
- **Ilsa** (spear) attacks: spends a 4 → 4 dmg, rat 4 to 1 HP — survives.
- **Rats** act: only rat 4 lives. It bites Sefa (1 die = 3). Sefa has not meleed this round → one die: spends a 4 → cuts 3. Leather untested. Zeroed.

Round 2.

- **Kragg** finishes rat 4. Threat overcome → **vent 2** → **Heat 6**.

Note: three rats fell to one die apiece (a face beats 5 HP), the fourth was defended off with a single die. A swarm's teeth are its count of attacks, not any one blow — and a Burner's armor soaks each blow separately, so numbers grind rather than spike.

Turn 5 — rest of Cellar 2.

- Loot niche: 120 gp, a **silvered knife** (1 slot). Sefa takes the knife.
- Torch 5/6; fresh torch lit.

Turn 6 — Cellar 3, the strongroom door. Masterwork lock (thief skill vs difficulty 10).

- Sefa (Craft, tools): Deal → $2d6+1 = 9$. Holds; time cost → **Heat 7**.
- Sefa again: $2d6+1 = 12$ ✓. Open.
- Wandering check: $d6 = 6$. Nothing.

Combat 2 — The Cellarer (a wight). Heat 7 → 9

Buried armed: **grave-sword** (2 slots) and a **grave-byrnies** (old chain — loot for a Burner, not AC on the block). HD 3 → **15 HP**. **Resistance 5 vs mundane arms** — grave-cold flesh and the mail as one wall — with silver the named weakness (it ignores the Resistance). The Referee announces it rising from its bier: **+2 Heat** → **9**.

Rolling Initiative. The wight's pool is **14 dice** — 3 (HD) + 2 (sword) + 9 (Heat) — the hot scene fighting back hard. It reads six 3s/4s: **Initiative 6, first.** As a named foe it takes the full Wound rules and strikes twice.

Round 1.

- **Wight**, two grave-sword blows:
 - → **Brand**: 3 dice (6,5,4 = 15). Brand has not meleed this round → one die: spends a 6 → 9 left; leather soaks 1 → **8 to HP**. Brand 5 → **-3: a Wound** (severity 3). Location 1d6=2, **torso, winded** — loses a Fuel die. **Shock Check: 2d6 + Sword (0) = 8 vs severity 3** ✓ — keeps his feet. (*Brand Fuel 7→5.*)
 - → **Ilsa**: 2 dice (5,5 = 10). Ilsa has not meleed → one die: a 4 → 10-4 = 6; her leather soaks 1 → **5 to HP**. Ilsa HP 3 → **-2: a Wound** (severity 2). Location 1d6=4, an **arm** — the spear-arm hangs useless until she reaches full HP. **Shock Check: 2d6 + Sword (0) = 6 vs severity 2** ✓ — she keeps her feet, shaken, one-armed. (*Fuel 8→7.*)
 - (*Wight spent 5 dice attacking; 9 left.*)
- **Kragg** attacks the wight (Veteran, two blows; 2-handed axe, 4 slots → two dice a blow) — having meleed, he Defends without limit for the rest of this round:
 - Blow A: 6,5,4 = 15. Wight has already meleed this round, so Defends freely: a 6 → 9 left, — Resistance 5 = **4**. Wight **15 → 11**.
 - Blow B: 5,4 = 9. Wight Defends a 5 → 4, -5 = **0**. Nothing. (*Wight Fuel 9→7.*)
- **Brand** attacks: sword, 1 die = 6. Wight Defends a 4 → 2, -5 = **0**. (*Wight 7→6 dice.*)
- **Ilsa** casts *dart* from her hand (Level 1) — one Action, spend at least 1 Fuel die and roll it: a 5 → **cast total 5**. The card **taps**. The wight **Defends** (no cap vs magic), committing a 2 → **overrun 3**. Pure sorcery: Resistance scoped to mundane arms — **3 to HP**. Wight **11 → 8**. (*Ilsa Fuel 7→6; wight 6→5 dice.*)
- **Sefa**, silvered knife (ignores Resistance): 1 die = 6. Wight Defends freely (already meleed): a 2 → 6-2 = **4** through. Wight **8 → 4**.

Round 2. Roll Initiative: refill +1 die each, lock order. The wight, having burned its 14-die burst, is winded — blows now arrive nearly whole.

- **Wight** (thin Fuel) jabs Kragg, 1 die = 3. Kragg has not meleed yet this round → one die: a 4 → cut.
- **Kragg**: 6,4 = 10. Having meleed, he will Defend freely for any further blows. Wight Defends its last die, a 2 → 8, -5 = **3**. Wight **4 → 1**. (*Even now, mundane barely tells.*)
- **Sefa** (silver): 5. Wight out of dice → no defense. Resistance bypassed → **5** through → past 0 by 4: **the killing Wound**. The Cellarer falls — chipped by silver and sorcery until even the wall of Resistance couldn't hold.
- **Ilsa**: *dart* is tapped and the spear-arm is dead — she falls back and covers the door. Ready magic is what sits ready in her hand; sleep recovers up to Sorcerie Level cards.
- Threat overcome → **vent 2 → Heat 7**.

Turn 7 — Strongbox.

- Carried out whole (2 slots; Kragg drops a torch bundle to fit it).
- Sefa checks for a second exit (Craft): Pay @ 7 → 2d6+1 = **11** ✓ — an old coal chute, out that way, skipping the flooded beam.

After

- **Downtime**: Heat cools to base; the job stayed quiet, so the town base is unchanged.
- **Take**: strongbox (Referee: 400 gp + deed papers), 120 gp, silvered knife, **the Cellarer's grave-sword** — old, fine make, a worn-off name (a Signature waiting to be read) — and its **grave-byrnies** (mail; Kragg claims it).
- **Wounds**: Ilsa sits at **-2 HP** (severity 2) with a dead arm; Brand at **-3** (severity 3) winded. After the fight, allies **help**; each makes **2d6 + Craft vs severity** (or die). Helped and passed: **1 HP per day** with food until **full HP**, then the Wound closes. Hour Rest does nothing while Wounded. Ilsa may spend a sleep-recovery card to untap *dart*.

- **Torches spent: 2. Turns: 7.**
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Procedure Notes

- **OSE clocks unchanged:** 10-minute turns, torch tracking, wandering checks every 2nd turn at 1-in-6.
 - **One roll out of combat:** 2d6 + Approach vs Cost. Traps — see [[Burners Principles#Pools, not fixed numbers]].
 - **Fuel is rolled on each Roll Initiative** — full pool on round 1; from round 2 on, refill one Fuel die per character level and roll those in, then lock order. The wight's 14-dice pool (swollen by 9 Heat) made round 1 murderous; by round 2 the refill was thin and the fight turned. A hot scene hits hardest on the first exchange.
 - **Damage is the faces of committed dice**, minus the defender's committed dice, minus a Burner's armor AC or a monster's Resistance — in that order. A blow is one die; a weapon of 3+ slots wielded in two hands can add a second. Monsters have no AC.
 - **Defense:** melee 1 die (no limit once you have meleed this round); missile 1 die (2 with Cover); magic no limit. **Block** spends one melee attack to redirect a blow onto yourself. **Cover** lets you spend 2 vs a missile; Spark while using a melee foe as Cover dumps the shot into them.
 - **The Wound model:** see [[Burners Principles#HP is plot armor; past 0 it gets real]].
 - **Casting is the same economy:** Ilsa's *dart* was one Action, one Fuel die rolled for the **cast total**; the card **tapped**; the wight Defended with a die of its own and ate the **overrun** to HP. Steel and sorcery spend the same pool. Sleep recovers up to Sorcerie Level cards.
 - **Resistance vs the named weakness:** the wight's Resistance 5 (grave-cold and the byrnie as one wall) made mundane steel almost useless, while silver ignored the Resistance (Sefa) and pure sorcery ignored it too (Ilsa's dart). The chip came from the weakness and the wand; silver finished it.
 - **The monster's slot/Fuel economy cuts both ways:** the wight spent its huge pool attacking and Defending, so by Sefa's turn it could spare only a die or two. Tie up its dice, then land the answer.
 - **Nobody died.** Shock kept them combat-effective; help after the fight bought the Craft survival checks. That is what a clean job looks like.
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Example 2 — The Gulls' Rest (a parley gone sharp)

The same crew, a week later, fencing the deed papers from the Rat-Cellars. This one starts as a social scene on Heart and turns into a fight mid-sentence — watch where the initiative roll lands.

Scene: a back table at the Gulls' Rest, evening crowd. The buyer is **Marlow**, a dockside fixer, flanked by two **bravos** and a quiet man with rings — a **sharper** (Sorcerer, Illusione). **Base Heat 4** (a quiet meet, but a crowded room and money on the table).

What's in hand matters tonight. Nobody walks into a parley holding a war-axe. Kragg's axe rides his back, Brand's sword is at his hip, Sefa's silvered knife is a holdout in her boot. Held slots only count on the Initiative roll if the thing is *in hand* when steel comes out.

The parley (Heart)

- **First meeting — Reaction roll** (Referee): 2d6 + Brand's Heart 1 = **8**. Cool but willing: Marlow will deal, at his price.
- **Brand opens** — the papers for 300 gp. That is a fair ask backed by real goods, so it simply works as an offer on the table (Step 1); no roll for whether the world listens.
- **Marlow lowballs** — 100 gp, and a smile. Brand wants the fixer's *real* ceiling — a read, and risky to press for: Pay @ Heat 4 → 2d6+1 = **9** ✓. The Referee gives it: Marlow is fronting for Varn's rival and will pay well over 300 — but he wants the crew *cheap or gone*.
- **Brand presses** — names the rival aloud, and asks 400. A hard squeeze on a made man: Pay @ Heat 4 → 2d6+1 = **6**, short → the squeeze shows, the table hears it → **Heat 5**.

- **Sefa reads the room** (Craft): Deal @ 5 → 2d6+1 = **10** ✓ — the bravos have shifted their stools clear of the table, and the ringed man's hands are under it. A revealed threat sets a floor: **Heat holds at 5, floor 5.**
- **Marlow leans back** — “Three hundred, then. Shake on it.” The Referee telegraphs: the sharper's lips are moving.

Steel comes out — roll initiative

The sharper casts a working at Brand. **A hostile spell is an attack: roll initiative.** He gains no free first strike for starting it — the whole room rolls with what it holds *right now*.

Side	Pool	Dice
Kragg (tankard, axe on back)	4 empty + 1 level	5
Sefa (knife in boot — a holdout)	4 empty + 1 level	5
Brand (sword at hip, not in hand)	4 empty + 1 level	5
Ilsa (5 Arcana declared; wand drip; no spear tonight)	5 Arcana + 1 level	6
Sharper (HD 1; Illusione hand; <i>Bewitch</i> ready)	1 HD + 6 Heat (enemy side, once)	7
Bravos (knives worn, ×2)	1 HD + 1 knife each	2 each

Initiative is the count of 3s and 4s. Kragg reads **3**, the sharper **2**, Ilsa **2**, Brand **1**, Sefa **1**, bravos **1** and **0**. **Kragg acts before the man whose spell started the fight.**

Round 1.

- **Kragg** (Veteran, two attacks; the axe stays sheathed — this is a tavern) spends one attack as a **Stunt**: heaves the table into the sharper. Force 5,4 = 9; the sharper Defends 4,2 = 6 → bowled over, **in the dirt**, and his concentration goes with his footing — but the working is already in the air; it resolves on his turn. Second attack spent to **Block** for Brand: if a blow comes for Brand, it redirects onto Kragg. (*Kragg 5→2 dice; order stays locked.*)
- **Sharper** (from the floor) finishes the cast — *Bewitch* (Illusione 1, ready in hand): commits 1 Fuel die = **5**. **Cast total 5**. The card taps. Brand may Defend — but **Ilsa is adjacent and Wards**: Sorcerie 1, she commits 1 Fuel die (a 4), cutting the cast to **1**. **Brand then Defends** with 1 die (a 3) → fully defended. No charm, no HP. (*Ilsa 6→5; Brand 5→4; sharper 7→6.*)
- **Ilsa** (her Action still unspent — Ward is not a turn): casts *dart* from her hand at the sharper. 1 die = **6** — cast total 6, and the 6 is a **Spark**. The card taps. The sharper, in the dirt and rattled, Defends with 2 dice: 3,2 = **5**. **Overrun 1** → 1 to HP (5 HP → 4). She spends the Spark on the working itself: the Referee lets the dart pin his casting hand to the floorboards — no ready cards until he frees it. (*Ilsa 5→4; sharper 6→4.*)
- **Bravo 1** lunges at Sefa, knife out: 1 die = **4**. Sefa has not meleed this round → one die: spends a 3 → 1 through, no armor tonight → **Sefa 3 HP → 2**. (*Sefa 5→4.*)
- **Brand** rises, sword *now* in hand (drawing comes free with his Action), and swings at bravo 1: 1 die = **5** → 5 dmg, bravo 1 (5 HP) **down**. (*Brand 5→4.*)
- **Sefa** draws the holdout — **1 Fuel to pull it in a fight** — and marks bravo 2. (*Sefa 4→3.*)
- **Bravo 2** hesitates — his partner is down, the sharper is pinned. **Morale check (2d6 under Morale 7): 6** — **holds**, barely. He circles.

Round 2. Roll Initiative: refill +1 die each, count, lock order; Kragg still tops it.

- **Kragg** hauls the sharper up by the collar — a **Stunt** to grapple, force 4,3 = 7 against a man in the dirt, pinned; the Referee rules there is no real contest. Held fast. (*Kragg 3→1.*)
- **Sharper**, ringless and in a fist: folds. “Enough — *enough*.”
- **Bravo 2** — his principal just quit: **Morale check: 10** — **breaks**, and he's out the door.
- Fight over. It never rose past the floor: **Heat 5**, and the room saw the *other* table start it.

After

- **The deal:** Marlow, dusting off his coat, pays **350 gp** for the papers — the crew's read was true, and the botched charm shamed his table, which is worth 50 gp of face. Money changes hands over a righted table.
- **The take:** 350 gp, one confiscated **ring** (Wizard Drip find; no bonus cards), and a bravo's knife in the floorboards.
- **Hurts:** Sefa 2/3 HP — an hour's rest with food refills her. Nobody wounded, nobody dead, nothing burned. In a tavern that is a masterpiece of restraint.
- **Heat:** cools to the town base at downtime. The Gulls' Rest will serve them again. Marlow will not forget.

Procedure Notes

- **Social scenes:** see [[Burners Principles#Two engines]] and [[Burners Principles#Heat is scene pressure]]. Heart pays for risky reads and squeezes as Pay rolls.
- **Heat is the social gauge too.** The meet opened at 4, climbed on a botched press, and a revealed threat set a floor. When steel came out, that same number armed the enemy side — the 6 Heat dice in the sharper's pool are the scene's temperature cashing in, added once for the whole side.
- **Declaring an attack is "roll initiative" — and the declarer is not first.** The sharper's charm started the fight and Kragg still beat him to the floor. A hostile working where no fight is underway triggers initiative like a drawn blade; nobody gets a free strike for moving first in the fiction.
- **You fight with what's in hand.** Tavern pools are thin: sheathed swords and slung axes throw no dice on the Initiative roll. Ilsa's declared Arcana slots carried her share. Brand's draw came free with his Action; Sefa's holdout cost the 1 Fuel a holdout costs.
- **Ward, shown:** Ilsa cuts the cast with $\leq$ Sorcerie Level Fuel; Brand then Defends the remainder. Control never lands partially on a clean stop.
- **Control is effect-only:** see [[Burners Principles#Harm and effect are separate lanes]]. Had the charm landed, Brand loses no HP — the crew attacks the reason (concentration, hand, skin).
- **Morale as written (2d6 vs the score):** the bravos were never going to die for Marlow's face. One blow and one bad round asked the question twice, and the second answer was the door.